

# The Bates Property Portfolio: An Investigation into the Past and the Present

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AMST/DCS 204: Archives Data and Analysis

December 4, 2024

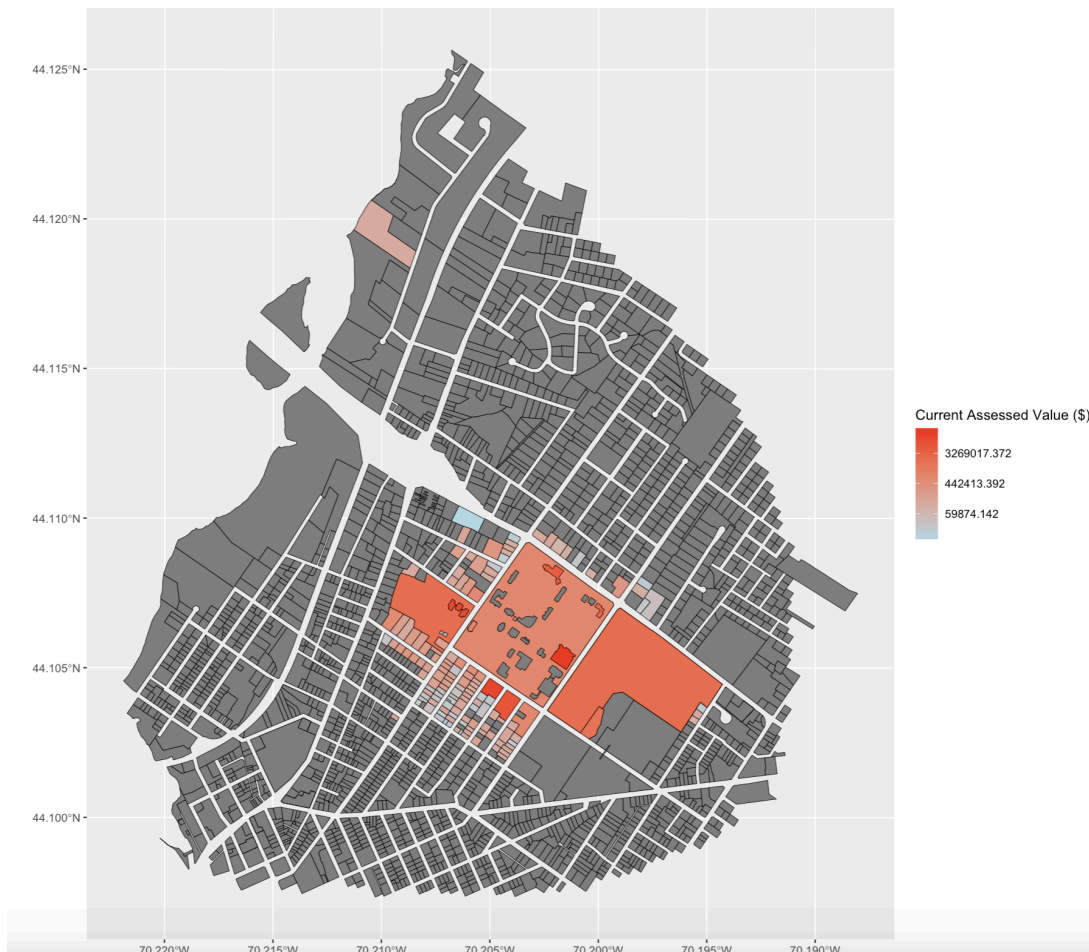


Figure 1

Our research is based on the following questions: How has Bates's property portfolio evolved over time, and what is its current value and composition? The evolution of Bates property ownership is critical to contextualizing the future of Bates as a student and future alumni. Additionally, this study helps build an understanding of the spatial distribution of Bates's footprint in modern Lewiston geography and investigates the role of Bates in the Lewiston real estate market. As members of the broader Lewiston community, an understanding of these questions is critical as our community members around us attempt to develop in the same market and community.

Our data came from the Lewiston Assessor's database website.<sup>1</sup> The website shows Lewiston's public tax assessment records, including property ownership information. After narrowing down the property list to properties owned by Bates College, we manually went through and recorded the address, current value, the price that Bates paid, and the date on which Bates acquired the property. In standardizing the data, we recorded the information exactly as it appeared on the website since that is how the matching data appears in the shape file of Lewiston, allowing us to easily map the properties using R. For properties with multiple dates of purchase, we interpreted the most recent date as the one to record as being by Bates College. We did not omit any properties that were listed as owned by the college, aside from analysis involving purchasing data or purchasing value. Many properties did not have a recorded sale value or sale date, so the rows with NA values in these columns were eliminated for analyses involving this information. The earliest purchasing date recorded is in 2003; thus, conclusions cannot be made about property purchased prior. However, strong conclusions and trends can be drawn from the limited data available regarding the last 21 years. For example, we feel that enough properties have the necessary information to run an accurate test determining statistical significance between the purchase price and current value to determine the appreciation or depreciation of new (last 21 years) Bates properties. Questions remain about this limited data set. It remains unclear when this data began to be recorded. Was it in 2003? or 2000? Additionally, is the purchasing information for all properties bought by Bates recorded on the Assessor's website? Or has Bates made purchases since 2003 that have not been recorded? Answers to these questions could be found with additional resources and time. However, we still built our data set sufficiently to answer the questions at hand.

According to the Lewiston Assessor's database, Bates College owns 164 properties in the city of Lewiston. While some of these properties have been in the college's possession since its inception in 1855, many of the properties are not a part of the existing campus, and have been purchased within the last two decades (Fig. 1, Fig. 6). Our findings clearly show that Bates is buying property with a primary focus on the portion of Lewiston directly southwest of the current campus. Specifically, a majority of property that Bates has purchased is between campus and Vale St. Based on the trend displayed in Fig. 3, we hypothesize that the college will continue to prioritize acquiring the remaining property on Wood St., Nichols St., and Bardwell St. In 2003, the college created the Campus Facilities Master Plan, which outlined the direction in which the campus would develop in the following two decades.<sup>2</sup> The plan details new campus facilities, as well as necessary improvements to current facilities. It also mentions the

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<sup>1</sup> <https://lewistonmaine.tylertech.com/search/CommonSearch.aspx?mode=OWNER>

<sup>2</sup> "Master Plan ('03-04)." Bates College Facility Services, December 18, 2018. Accessed December 4, 2024. <https://www.bates.edu/facility/campus-improvements/campus-facilities-master-plan-2003-04/>.



Figure 2



Figure 3

possibility of the creation of a new quad in the Wood St. area.<sup>3</sup> It has been over 20 years since the plan was enacted, and no such quad exists. However, given the consistent purchasing of property in the Wood St. area since 2003, as well as the goals put forth by the Facilities Master Plan, it seems likely that Bates College would like to continue acquiring properties surrounding the campus. Bates is also acquiring property in the Mountain Ave. and Ware St. area, in between Mt. David and Russell St. (Fig. Given the trend of the college purchasing properties in clusters, as well as its commitment to campus development, it is likely that this area will continue to be a target for acquisition as well.

In order to determine the statistical significance between the current property value of Bates properties and the amount that Bates paid for said properties, we ran a Wilcoxon test on the two vectors. It was determined that a Wilcoxon test would be more suitable to the datasets than a t-test because the values were not normally distributed. The test returned a p-value of 0.02285, which suggests statistical significance as it is lower than 0.05. Fig. 5 shows the difference between the acquisition and current price in Bates properties. Based on Fig 5., as well as the results of the Wilcoxon test, we can see that there is a significant difference between the two values. Almost all of the properties that have a date of purchase that is publicly available have depreciated in value since being acquired by Bates. Though many properties were used as Covid-19 isolation housing from 2020-2021, they have gone unused by the college since the institutional shift away from Covid-19 restrictions. Additionally, while some off-campus properties may be used as faculty housing, the college leases the buildings to

<sup>3</sup> "Step 3 – Final Plan." Bates College Facility Services, December 18, 2018. Accessed December 4, 2024. <https://www.bates.edu/facility/campus-improvements/step-3-final-plan/>.

Wilcoxon rank sum test with continuity correction

data: bates\_buy\$Current\_Assesed\_Value and bates\_buy\$Sale\_Amount  
 $W = 342$ ,  $p\text{-value} = 0.02285$   
 alternative hypothesis: true location shift is not equal to 0

Figure 4

Figure 5

employees at market rate, offering little incentive for their use.<sup>4</sup> Given the depreciation of property value across the board, we hypothesize that the lack of use, and therefore lack of upkeep, of these properties is leading to a loss of value over time. Alternatively, based on the lofty goals set out in the Campus Facilities Master Plan, and the need for large clusters of property to achieve those goals, it may be that Bates is paying more than the value of the property at the time of purchase in order to incentivize Lewiston residents to sell their homes to the school.

Fig 6. shows that with the exception 2007-2009, Bates has been consistently purchasing property in Lewiston since 2003. One explanation for this gap in purchases is that from 2007-2009 the world experienced a major economic recession. During a time of financial instability, Bates most likely shifted away from its priority being expansion to a more sustainable economic model. The property value of Bates' purchases has not drastically changed since the record began in 2003, and the sale values remain less than 500,000, aside from one purchase. Notably, in 2021 Bates made the purchase of 96 Campus Ave for 1,950,000. This is the only property purchase on record for direct expansion of student housing. While the other purchases may be demolished and replaced by new student housing in decades to come, the 96 Campus Ave purchase may have been done to address an urgent shortage of student housing.

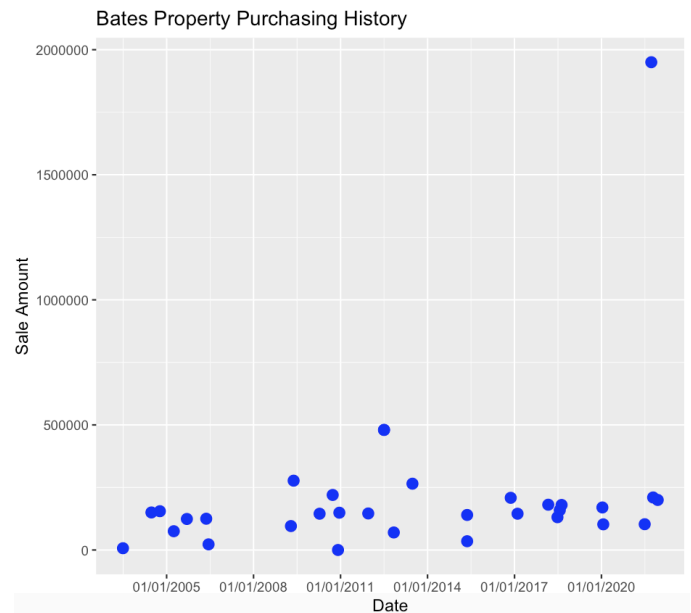
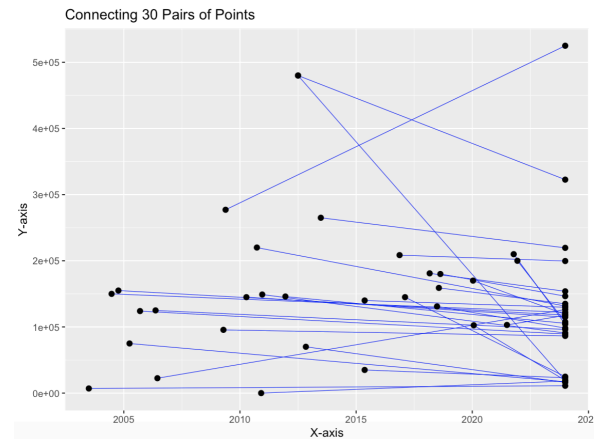


Figure 6

<sup>4</sup> 1. Anelise Shrout, lecture to class, 2024.